

Draft - expert review pending

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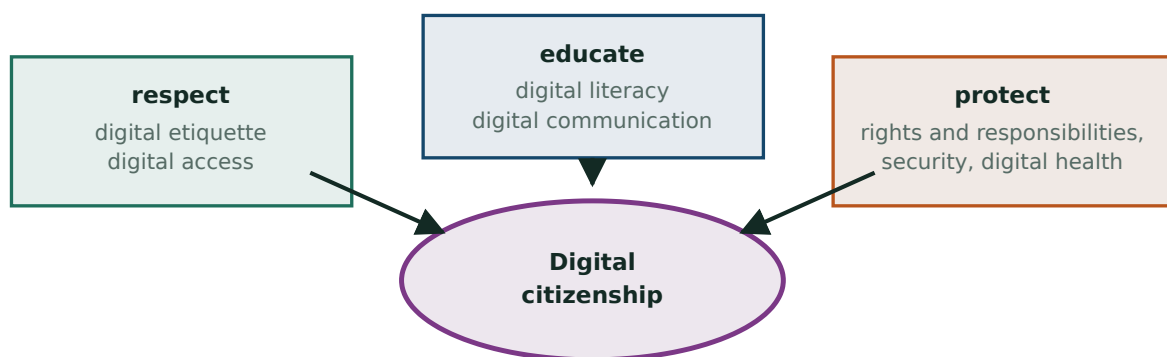
Topic 5.1 - Digital citizenship

A real classroom situation

Two pupils at a Sukkur school have a falling-out. By evening, one has posted the other's photograph in a class group with a mocking caption; a dozen classmates have forwarded it to other groups by morning. Nobody broke a lock or picked a pocket. The school's discipline rules, written for corridors and playgrounds, say nothing about forwarding. Yet everyone involved knows, somewhere, that something wrong happened. Digital citizenship is the name for that knowing: the standards of behaviour you carry with you when you use technology - and this topic is about making those standards explicit enough to teach.

The dimensions of digital citizenship

Rights and responsibilities, arriving together



Every right arrives tied to a responsibility: expression to non-harm, privacy to respecting others' data, information to checking it.

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Explanation

Digital citizenship and its dimensions

Digital citizenship is the ability to participate in digital society safely, ethically and constructively - to use technology in ways that respect yourself and other people. The phrase turns "user" into "citizen" deliberately: a citizen has rights, and a citizen has responsibilities, and the two come together.

The commonly taught dimensions group into three families. **Respect:** digital etiquette (how you behave, Topic 5.2's subject) and digital access - recognising that not everyone has the same devices, data or signal, and that a class where homework requires a smartphone quietly excludes the child without one.

Educate: digital literacy (judging what is true, which Unit 6 takes up) and digital communication - choosing the right tool and tone for the message. **Protect:** digital rights and responsibilities (knowing what you may demand and what you owe), digital security (Unit 4's habits) and digital health (sleep, screen time, and the difference between connecting and scrolling). The European DigComp framework makes the same point from the competence side: its five areas include communication and collaboration, safety, and problem solving - being good with technology means being good with people through technology (Vuorikari, Kluzer, and Punie, 2022).

Rights arrive tied to responsibilities

A citizen's right	The matching responsibility	One classroom example
to learn and express yourself online	to express yourself without harming others	disagree with a view, not mock the person
to keep your data private	to respect others' data as you want yours respected	do not forward a classmate's photo without asking
to access information	to check before you share	verify a forwarded claim before passing it on
to be free from harassment	to report harassment you witness	screenshot and tell a teacher instead of laughing along
to use school devices	to use them for learning purposes	the lab computer is not for personal chats
Read each row across: the right you hold, the duty it brings, and what it looks like in class.		

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The key idea is that every right arrives tied to a responsibility. You have a right to express yourself online; you have a responsibility not to use expression to harm - the photograph in the opening story was expression, and it was harm. You have a right to privacy; you have a responsibility to protect other people's, which is Unit 4's data-protection duty seen from the citizen's side. You have a right to information; you have a responsibility to check it before you pass it on, because a forwarded falsehood travels under your name.

For a teacher, digital citizenship is doubly yours. You are a citizen, and you are the model: the class that watches its teacher forward an unverified message to the parents' group has learned a rule, just not a good one. And pupils cannot learn citizenship from a lecture alone - they learn it from the norms the school actually enforces, which is why this unit's summative task is a code the class writes for itself.

A caution against a common misconception: digital citizenship is not just "being polite online". Politeness is one habit within it. The opening story was not about politeness; it was about a photograph, consent, and harm - citizenship questions, not etiquette questions. Topic 5.2 takes up the etiquette slice; this topic holds the whole.

Activity: Rights and responsibilities cards

Work in pairs. About 15 minutes.

1. Your teacher gives each pair ten cards: five naming a right (express yourself, keep your data private, access information, be free from harassment, use school devices) and five naming a responsibility (do not harm others, respect others' data, check before sharing, report harassment, use devices for learning).
2. Match each right to the responsibility it arrives tied to, and write one sentence for each pair: what the pairing looks like in one real classroom situation.
3. Take the opening story of this topic (the forwarded photograph). Identify which right was violated and which responsibility was ignored - name both, in the vocabulary of the cards.
4. Compare pairings with another pair and argue any disagreement by pointing to the harm, not the rule.

Check your understanding

1. Define digital citizenship in one sentence. (*Remember*)
2. Name the three families of dimensions (respect, educate, protect) and one dimension in each. (*Remember*)
3. A school sets digital homework that requires a smartphone, and three pupils in the class have none. Which dimension does this touch, and what would a responsible school do? (*Apply*)
4. Explain why "being polite online" is too narrow a definition of digital citizenship, using the photograph story. (*Understand*)

Summary

Digital citizenship is participation in digital society with rights and responsibilities that arrive together: respect (etiquette, access), educate (literacy, communication) and protect (rights, security, health). Every right is

tied to a responsibility - expression to non-harm, privacy to respecting others' data, information to checking it. Teachers carry it doubly: as citizens, and as the model the class learns from.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define digital citizenship and name its three families of dimensions.
- ☐ I can match a right to its tied responsibility with a classroom example.
- ☐ I can judge a described online act as responsible or irresponsible and name the dimension involved.

Try this at your practicum school

Find out whether your practicum school has any written rule about online behaviour (pupil-to-pupil messages, photographs, class groups). Write two sentences: what exists today, and the one rule you would add first.

Summative task

Draft the first five articles of a "class code of responsible ICT use" for a Class 7 group, each article in one sentence, each pairing one right with its responsibility. Under each article, write one line naming the classroom situation it answers.

Marking guide (10 marks):

- Five articles, each one sentence and workable: 3 marks.
- Each article genuinely pairs a right with a responsibility rather than a bare prohibition (Analyse): 4 marks.
- Each situation line is realistic for Class 7: 2 marks.
- Clear writing: 1 mark.

Further reading

- Vuorikari, R., Kluzer, S., & Punie, Y. (2022). *DigComp 2.2: The Digital Competence Framework for Citizens*. Publications Office of the European Union. <https://doi.org/10.2760/115376>
- Common Sense Media. *Digital Citizenship Curriculum*. <https://www.commonsense.org/education/digital-citizenship>
- Higher Education Commission, Pakistan. *ICT and Digital Literacy Guidelines*. <https://hec.gov.pk/english/services/universities/Pages/PolicyGuidelines.aspx>

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